AJP Policy

Eliminating the Use of Animals in Entertainment

Ban Horse Racing

The Animal Justice Party Aotearoa NZ (AJP) is opposed to all forms of horse racing and is committed to eliminating the use of animals for human ‘sport’ and ‘entertainment’.

Horse racing for profit includes flat racing, jumps racing, and harness racing. Horse racing in New Zealand is less associated with a sense of glamour of the past and is increasingly controversial owing to the inherent cruelty and risks involved. Every year, despite efforts to improve safety and regulate the industry, hundreds of horses suffer pain, stress, injuries, and even death as a result of being raced.

Contrary to popular belief, horses do not willingly participate in racing; many have to be coerced into the starting gates, highlighting the inherent lack of consent in the activity.

The use of whips, tongue ties, spurs, and other tools, including performance-enhancing drugs, to control and push horses to their limits only exacerbates their suffering, both physically and psychologically. For example, in July 2024, in one week two thoroughbreds collapsed and died at the end of their races from heart attacks. The practice of "wastage," where uncompetitive or excess animals are killed, further underscores the disregard for the lives of these animals.

AJP advocates for non-violent, community-friendly entertainment that aligns with society’s progressive concerns and higher ethical and moral principles, and does not exploit and undermine animals’ well-being.

Key Objectives:

1. Ban all forms of horse racing in Aotearoa NZ.

   Interim measures, while we work towards the ban, include:

2. Ensure full transparency and accountability by having a public birth to death registry for all horses born into the racing industry, whether these horses perform in official events or not.
3. Decrease the number of race meetings to alleviate the pressure on horses and reduce the frequency of injuries and fatalities associated with racing.
4. Prohibit cruel practices and tools, such as the use of whips, tongue ties and spurs.
5. Prohibit the racing of horses under three years of age.
6. End the slaughter of ex-racehorses.
7. Provide ex-racehorses with proper care, rehabilitation and rehoming for fulfilling post-racing life.
8. Reallocate government funding and subsidies to transition those employed by the industry into non-exploitative jobs and careers.